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For years, comparing a base iPhone with a Samsung Galaxy S 'vanilla' variant never felt entirely fair. Apple's non-Pro models always came with compromises like lower refresh rate, fewer features, and missing the few essential bits, so that you'll naturally drift away towards the Pro. However, that changed with the iPhone 17. This is the first time Apple's base model feels complete. You now get a 120Hz display, improved battery life, stronger performance, and even improved Apple Intelligence. Samsung, on the other hand, has stayed consistent with the Galaxy S26. It doesn't rely on big changes. Instead, they refined what already works like a compact design, strong hardware, versatile cameras, and a feature-rich experience that continues to evolve.

Display experience

The display is where Apple finally closes a long-standing gap. The iPhone 17 now features a 6.3-inch LTPO OLED panel. This is a ProMotion display, meaning there's finally support for a 120Hz refresh rate on a standard iPhone. This alone changes how the phone feels in daily use. Folks who have used old-generation standard iPhones like the 14, 15 or even the 16, will instantly appreciate the boost in speed and smoothness. Thanks to the 120Hz refresh rate.

Samsung, on the other hand, also gets you a 6.3-inch LTPO panel on the Galaxy S26. They call it a Dynamic AMOLED 2x display, and it also has a variable 1-120Hz refresh rate.

In the real-world, side by side, both displays are excellent. If I have to break it down, the iPhone 17 leans towards a more natural colour reproduction, while

Samsung opts for slightly more vibrant and punchy colours.

However, brightness is where Samsung gets ahead. In our brightness test, the iPhone 17 reaches around 2,160 nits in outdoor conditions, which is more than sufficient. The Galaxy S26 takes this even higher to around 2,650 nits, and that difference becomes quite noticeable under direct sunlight.

Basically, if you choose the iPhone 17, you get a bright and reliable display. However, if you pick the Galaxy S26, the display experience is brighter and more vibrant. You can also tweak the display profile on the S26, something the iPhone doesn't let users do.

Camera performance

Just like its predecessors, the iPhone 17 still uses a dual-rear camera setup. However, both the primary and ultra-